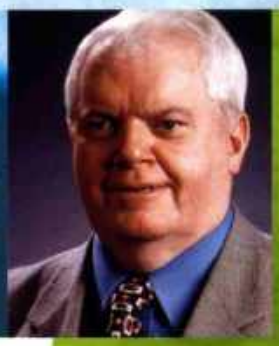
ISSUE 1

GALLIONS grapevine

August 2000

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

A new beginning



John Fahy, Chair of Gallions Housing Association, writes:

Gallions Housing Association is now up and running. The Housing Corporation granted us registration on the 8th of June. The Board of Gallions has spent much of its time preparing the organisation to meet the necessary changes and demands that will be required in the future.

We will shortly launch a wide-ranging survey (Gallions Customer First) of residents of Thamesmead. (see page 5). We want to know from you how you currently value the service, what changes if any need to be made and how we can work together to improve the quality of life for all residents. Please help us by completing the questionnaire and participating in the Focus Groups. We want to hear from all residents – young and old.

We all face an enormous challenge. There is a lot to do to improve the environment, reduce the amount of crime and vandalism and to work with other agencies to promote a brighter future for young people. We all know how damaging anti-social behaviour is to many neighbourhoods in Thamesmead. We propose to strengthen the tenancy agreement, extend our enforcement procedures and to work closely with the Police and others to create better neighbourhoods. There is no quick fix, no easy solution, but we must be much more than a Social Landlord just collecting the rent and carrying out necessary repairs. We cannot sort out these problems alone. We need your help and support.

In the coming months we will look closely at what we can do over time to improve the quality of social housing in Thamesmead. We will consult widely with all residents on the proposals we bring forward. Our priority is to maximise the involvement of all residents and to work with you on a wide range of issues.

We do want to hear from you on any suggestions that you may have to assist us in developing the strategy I have outlined. Please write or come and talk to me.

I do look forward to your participation.

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Welcome

Welcome to the first edition of "Gallions Grapevine", your new newsletter from Gallions Housing Association. I hope you find it both useful and enjoyable.

We are going to publish "Gallions Grapevine" four times a year, so I hope it becomes something that you look forward to.

If you have any suggestions for future features, would like to contribute an article, or have any comments about "Gallions Grapevine", then please write to me, Caroline Wilson, at Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.



Caroline Wilson
Editor

See back page for your list of contacts

Viewpoint



It is a pleasure and a privilege to contribute to this new publication as Chief Executive of Gallions Housing Association. Some of you may have heard me say before that one of the important changes we have to make is to improve communications with our customers, that is our tenants and chargepayers.

This newsletter, and some of the issues raised in it, provides evidence that we are trying to do something to improve communication – but it is only part of the solution. Communication is a two-way thing and we also have to give you every opportunity to communicate with us and then listen to what you have to say.

We have been very busy establishing Gallions, completing the transfer from Thamesmead Town and seeking registration with the Housing Corporation as a Registered Social Landlord. These tasks are complete and we are now in a position to start delivering on the promises we made during the consultation period prior to the ballot last year. There are some immediate benefits for all. Our registration as a Registered Social Landlord removes restrictions on housing benefit and gives all tenants additional rights and protection. We can now also work even closer with our local authority partners and begin to access grants for regeneration and the building of more affordable houses for rent.

I am keen to ensure that residents and visitors to Thamesmead are aware that the area is "under new management". In my view the best way to achieve this is to make a visible difference that people notice and comment on. One of the main assets of Thamesmead is the green and open nature of the area compared to other parts of London. This is a strength we should protect and defend. In the next few weeks we plan to take measures to improve the standard of landscape maintenance, improve the cleanliness of the open areas and deal more quickly with the removal of graffiti. We do not control all the open spaces, but the environment that people live in has a big impact on their quality of life. I am convinced we can do more to play our part in enhancing the environment. I hope you soon notice a difference. I am sure I will get to know if this is not the case.

We are looking for continued improvement rather than short-lived fixes. We may never achieve perfection, but your role will be to let us know whether or not we are continually improving and heading in that direction.

Tony Cotter
Chief Executive

020 8310 1500

ring this number for all Gallions departments

3 into 1

Three into one does go

I have heard a number of people ask about the relationship between Gallions, Trust Thamesmead and Tilfen and I am happy to provide some explanation.

Let me start by reminding you of the role of each organisation.

- **Gallions, as you know, is responsible for housing in the Thamesmead area and providing management, maintenance and social housing development.**

- **Trust Thamesmead is a charity working for the benefit of all residents in Thamesmead, not just tenants and chargepayers. Its main focus is economic and community regeneration for the area.**

- **Tilfen is a private property company that owns the business parks, commercial properties and undeveloped land in the area. Like any successful business its aim is to generate profit through its commercial activities.**

Thus, all three organisations are separate and have their own focus and operate independently.

However there is a relationship between the organisations that has been designed to ensure the maximum benefit for the wider Thamesmead community. Tilfen, like other businesses, is expected to use profit to pay dividends to its shareholders. However, Tilfen has only two shareholders: Gallions Housing Association and Trust Thamesmead which are, of course, both charitable not for profit organisations.

In practice this means that Gallions and Trust Thamesmead jointly appoint the Board of Tilfen, agree their business and ensure that profits generated by Tilfen are retained for the benefit of the community by receiving the dividend payments.

In addition the Boards of all three organisations are determined to work together in partnership for the benefit of Thamesmead and its residents. Although each has its own role to play all three also recognise the importance of working closely together.

I hope this helps to provide some explanation. If it does not, or there are other issues you would like to know about, please tell me, I am still listening.

Going green

Gallions Ecopark

In this day and age we all recognise the importance of protecting our environment. An exciting new project has environmental protection issues at its heart.

Already on the drawing board, this project is the £3.6million EcoPark. This is a groundbreaking development of 39 environmentally friendly houses in the Urban Village close to the Hill.

Construction of these 3 and 4 bedroom homes is planned to start on site in February 2001. Due to take a year to complete, the homes will be built for rent. They will incorporate the most modern energy-saving features and ecologically sustainable materials.

The design is yet to be finalised and more details will be available on this project later this year.



Artists impression of the Ecopark Visitors Centre which will be on the site.
Printed with kind permission of Tilfen Ltd.

Have you got an old banger you want to get rid of?



Gallions Housing Association gets reports of over 50 cars a month dumped or abandoned on private roads or parking areas. Often these cars are then vandalised and in some cases even set alight. This obviously has an implication for public safety.

To deter residents from leaving cars to just rot away, we are offering a FREE SERVICE. As long as you are able to hand over to us the appropriate documentation to prove ownership, such as a log book or certificate of ownership, we will remove your car free of charge.

Contact our Security Services for further information on 020 8310 1500.

Urban village moves into new phase

Following the successful completion of Phase I of Gallions Reach Urban Village, Phase 2 is now underway. If your are in any doubt as to where this is, there are flags marking the site on Western Way.

This new phase includes the development of 279 houses, being built by Barratts, Fairclough Homes, Persimmon and Beazer. These homes are going up on 15 acres of land belonging to Tilfen Ltd. Work on the houses started in March and the development is expected to take 2 years to complete.

Of the homes being built, 30 will be for rent. They are made up of 2 and 3 bedroom houses, 6 of which are fully accessible for people in wheelchairs.

Once complete, these will be bought and managed by Gallions Housing Association and made available to people on the waiting lists.

Work on these homes, which will be built to the highest standards, is due to start very soon. We expect the first homes will be available to tenants in approximately six months time.

The cost of the project to the Association is just over £2.5million. We hope that this will just be the start for us of a major building programme that will take place over the coming few years.

A resource for all



The Tenant and Charge-Payers Resource Centre is open to all Tenants & Charge-Payers of Gallions Housing Association who wish to form a Tenants & Residents Association in their local area and need the resources to do so.

The Centre has five computers to enable you to write letters, newsletters, leaflets and posters. You can photocopy information, laminate posters, make labels and much more. The Centre is available for meetings and also has a library of information.

Here are some of the groups who already use the Centre:

- The Estate Management Boards.
- Tenants & Residents Association for meetings and training.
- The Family Service Unit at Maran Way, in partnership with Gallions Housing Association, is setting up a housing information drop-in centre for Chinese and Vietnamese residents
- Community groups will also be able to benefit from the Centre
- The Thamesmead and Abbey Wood Single Regeneration Budget project
- Bexley Afro Caribbean Community Association (BACCA)

Do you fancy a look around?
Are you interested in helping start a Tenants & Residents Association?
Have you never done anything like this before but want to see what it's all about?

If so, contact:
Linda Nash – Tenant Participation Officer on 020 8320 3451

The Centre is adjacent to Gallions Housing Association Offices Harrow Manor Way and is by Bookings Only.

Brushing up your skills

We see training as a key way in which we can help tenants and residents play a greater role in how their homes are managed. We have started a programme of training sessions for Tenants & Residents Associations.

As the number of Tenants & Residents Associations is growing, the need for training is increasing. There have been 2 successful training sessions held so far this year.

Command of Committees

The first session, held in May, was for Committee Skills for Tenants & Residents Associations. At this training session tenants representatives learnt about the roles of Chair, Secretary, Treasurer and Committee members. This was an introductory session and more in depth sessions on the specific roles will take place in the future.

Combating Techno-Fear

The second session was a four-week, (10 hours) introduction to Computers held in June. The course was designed for complete beginners and the Tenants & Residents who took part were introduced to word processing and spreadsheets. At the end of the four weeks the people who took part had learnt to use the computer to set a letter and a leaflet, using different typefaces (fonts). They also mastered how to do simple calculations using a spreadsheet.

What They Said

At the end of the sessions the people who attended the courses were asked for their views on the training. These are some of the comments made:

"Well structured lessons and enjoyable." *Ray Hill*

"A wonderful introduction to computers, well run, aimed at the right level and very enjoyable." *Don Tidey*

"I liked the way I was shown and how patient the trainer was. I would recommend it to any one." *Tracey Mahy*

"Well presented, especially for me as a novice. " *Ken Sealey*

"These sessions have taken away the initial fear I had of computers, the trainer was superb, very patient and tolerant. I have enjoyed every moment of the course." *Olive Williams*

FEEDBACK

FEEDBACK is to be a regular feature of "Gallions Grapevine". It is a space in the newsletter for your comments, suggestions ideas or views.

What do you think of "Gallions Grapevine"? Have you any comments on our service – good or bad? What is your view of living in Thamesmead?

Let us know by writing to FEEDBACK, Gallions Grapevine, C/O Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.



A better place to live

One of our key policies is that which deals with nuisance and anti-social behaviour. Many of us have experienced the effects that this sort of behaviour can have on our daily lives.

We are committed to tackling this problem in all its forms, so that our residents can live in peace.

We will investigate all reports of nuisance, harassment, racial harassment and general anti-social behaviour. Where possible, we will take appropriate action to stop the problem.

BUT, we cannot do this on our own. We rely on YOUR co-operation in dealing with offenders.

If you are a victim of anti-social behaviour you should contact your Housing Officer for help and support. We will take all reports seriously and will work with all of the other groups involved – such as the police – to make sure that cases are dealt with.

Do you have any views on this subject? If so, why not write to us at FEEDBACK?

Finding out what you think – Gallions Customer First

Gallions Housing Association is pleased to announce Gallions Customer First, a long term initiative that gives, as the name suggests, priority to your needs.

We believe that Gallions Customer First will give the Association a more open, and responsive approach by putting your needs and views at the centre of everything we do.

It is about acting upon your views and improving all aspects of our services by taking positive action. We intend to build upon our strengths and to implement programs of improvement. Gallions Customer First will give you the opportunity to be involved and to shape our services.

Gallions Housing Association has set up a dedicated team who will lead this work. The Gallions Customer First team are currently seeking your views about the services we provide and additional services you would wish to see introduced, if you have not already received a survey form, you will soon.

We are committed to delivering the best possible services and to making Gallions Housing Association something that you are proud to be a part of. It is vital you return the survey form to us. You will also have the chance to enter a free prize draw.

Your views count – please use the survey opportunity to let us know what they are.

See back page for your full list of contacts

Board Profile

We will be introducing the Board of Gallions Housing Association Directors in each issue. Next issue will feature Anthony Cox and Mike French.



William Ekinu

William is currently an Independent Board member of Gallions Housing Association.

He is a Policy Development Worker with GRECA. We have a local relationship with GRECA and provide them with accommodation for some of their clients. William has extensive Community Work Experience with a wide knowledge of Ethnic Minority Housing, Training and Social Needs. As a member of a number of Voluntary Organisations' Management Committees he has a clear understanding of how Board and Committees work. He is aware of the Housing needs of the local residents and can contribute positively through the Board towards meeting these needs.

Board Meetings

Gallions Housing Association's Board of Management meets on a regular basis. The meetings are open to all residents. In order to accommodate any residents who wish to attend, you would need to contact Caroline Wilson at our offices, (address below) prior to any meeting to make arrangements.

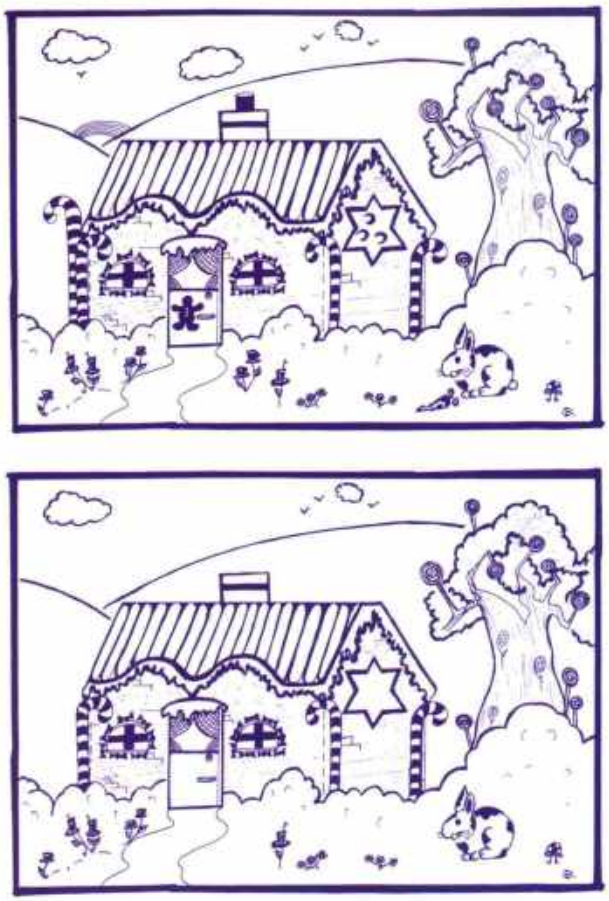
The dates of the next meetings are:

Monday 18 September 2000
Monday 30 October 2000
Monday 11 December 2000
Monday 22 January 2001

All meetings are held at Gallions Housing Association offices, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.

Just for fun

Spot the 10 differences



wordsearch

Can you find the surnames of ten British Prime Ministers of the 20th Century? The names can be found horizontally, vertically or diagonally.

X	C	M	V	W	C	K	W	W	K	J	P
P	G	A	A	A	C	H	N	R	M	A	M
T	D	C	L	E	K	L	R	C	P	I	E
Q	B	M	O	L	X	I	E	P	Q	O	R
L	F	I	V	N	A	D	O	B	R	R	P
R	P	L	Q	L	E	G	H	E	A	T	H
X	Y	L	B	N	A	H	H	T	M	W	D
U	Z	A	S	G	O	C	G	A	W	Q	R
H	G	N	B	F	T	S	J	O	N	Y	Z
E	M	X	O	A	H	O	L	L	F	E	Q
O	V	C	H	U	R	C	H	I	L	L	H
H	H	T	I	U	Q	S	A	O	W	B	X

In this month

1923 American, Henry Sullivan, swims the channel in 28 hours
1930 24 people in the UK die in a heatwave
1936 The speaking clock begins
1942 The new Waterloo Bridge opens
1948 Rationing of shoes and furnishing fabrics ends
1949 The Suez crisis worsens
1960 Publication of "Lady Chatterley's Lover" is cancelled
1970 Coronation Street celebrates 1000 episodes
1976 Lord Howell becomes "Minister for Rain" during drought
1985 Amstrad launches its Personal Computer

What's coming

Look out in the next issue for date of the Tenant Conference. We are currently looking at holding this major event in either October or November.

Contacts

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London SE2 9XH

Office opening hours:
Monday to Friday
between 9am and 5pm.

Main Switchboard
(for housing and other enquiries)
020 8310 1500

Repairs Freephone
0800 838481

Comfort 2000 Heating
020 8320 3422

Shield Security
020 8320 3439

Interserve
0800 389 0154

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾，請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phòng bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐ *(please tick one)*

Name: .....

Address: .....

.....

Return to: Caroline Wilson (Translation Requests), Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH